

Understanding Baltimore's AI Ecosystem

A Community-Grounded Compass for AI Navigation

Center for AI Learning and Community-Engaged Innovation

June 2026



Baltimore's AI Moment

- AI is already affecting how people learn, work, access services, solve problems, and make decisions.
- Baltimore has AI-related efforts underway, but they are not yet connected by a shared understanding of all stakeholders' lived experiences.
- To move forward responsibly, Baltimore needs more than tools or policies. It needs a clearer picture of the people who will use, avoid, question, shape, or be affected by AI.

Where We Are Now

- AI efforts are emerging across sectors but remain fragmented.
- Many institutions are still learning who uses AI, who does not, and why.
- Community understanding varies widely.
- Some stakeholders see AI as useful or exciting; others see it as confusing, risky, inaccessible, or irrelevant.
- Without a shared picture of Baltimore's AI users, efforts may miss the people and the communities they are meant to serve.

Where We Want to Be

Baltimore wants an AI future characterized by:

- Broad access to AI tools and opportunities across communities
- Practical AI education for all Baltimore stakeholders
- Better quality of life through tools that help people learn, work, create, care, and solve problems
- Measured adoption that protects, builds trust, and strengthens community capacity
- Coordination across sectors so efforts reinforce each other rather than operate separately

How to Use This Report

This report should help readers:

- Understand current AI perceptions and behaviors
- See patterns across Baltimore civic and economic ecosystems
- Use personas to guide outreach, programming, education, workforce planning, and civic decision-making
- Identify missing voices and future research needs
- Treat personas as living frameworks that should evolve over time

Table of Contents

1. Project Background
2. Project Objectives
3. Methodology
4. Overarching Findings
5. Meet Baltimore's AI Users
6. What the Personas Reveal

Why Baltimore Needs a Community-Grounded AI Compass



- AI activity is growing across Baltimore, but efforts remain fragmented.
- There is limited shared understanding of how AI stakeholders use, question, avoid, or experience AI.
- Without that understanding, programs and policies risk missing the people they are meant to support.
- This project creates a starting compass for broad access, practical education, improved quality of life, and measured adoption.

Our Purpose

We want to start a productive, practical conversation about AI in Baltimore City.

This project exists to:

- Encourage thoughtful conversation within and across Baltimore City's communities
- Foster deeper understanding of AI's potential impacts
- Give Baltimore stakeholders a starting compass for planning, outreach, education, and responsible adoption
- Identify what still needs to be understood, tested, and refined



About CAILI

Our mission is to cultivate AI-literate and community-engaged leaders who apply artificial intelligence to solve real-world challenges, expand access, strengthen communities, and improve quality of life.

CAILI's Role:

- Build AI literacy and fluency among students, faculty, and community
- Translate community insight into useful guidance for decision-making
- Connect research, education, innovation, and community engagement
- Help Baltimore move from fragmented AI efforts toward coordinated, measured action



Why Mindgrub?

Mindgrub is a local Baltimore technology company with deep expertise in user research, as well as technology strategy, design, and engineering.

Mindgrub's award-winning campaigns, web and mobile experiences, and digital solutions are integral to making Baltimoreans' lives better, their jobs easier, and helping businesses thrive.



Project Objectives

- 1 Understand Baltimore's existing AI ecosystem and define common use-cases
- 2 Gauge resident sentiment around AI tools across user types
- 3 Uncover opportunities for Baltimore City to embrace AI for the benefit of residents and their communities

Key Questions

Theme 1

What do people use AI for, and what are their processes?

Theme 2

How do people gauge their own understanding of AI tools?

Theme 3

What concerns do people have about AI tools and using them?

Theme 4

How can Baltimore City leverage AI tools to benefit residents?

What do people use AI for, and what are their processes?

1

How frequently do users turn to AI to complete personal or professional tasks?

2

What are users' common workflows when interfacing with AI tools?

3

How do users determine whether or not a task is better completed using AI?

4

What are common pitfalls users face when interacting with AI tools?

How do people gauge their own understanding of AI tools?

1

How do users self-identify their experience using AI tools?

2

What knowledge gaps do users feel they have with AI platforms?

3

What type of tasks do users not know whether AI can help or not?

4

What do users feel the future looks like with AI technology?

What concerns do people have about AI tools and using them?

1

Do users hold any pre-existing concerns around their own AI usage?

2

Do users feel AI tools are equally accessible to all Baltimore residents?

3

How have AI tools impacted users' work since their emergence?

How can Baltimore City leverage AI tools to benefit residents?

1

What hopes do users hold for how AI can assist communities?

2

What concerns do users have about how Baltimore may adopt AI?

3

Do users hold existing ideas around how Baltimore could leverage AI?

4

What questions do users have regarding how AI is used throughout Baltimore?

Methodology

Landscape Assessment

This exploration began in late February 2026 and continued over the course of three months. It was built upon the foundation of previously conducted research that shaped multiple rounds of group and individual interviews and surveys.

Through this project, we uncovered many use cases and sentiments around AI, but also how little guidance people were operating with to navigate this new technological ecosystem.

Specific activities included:

- Review of relevant academic AI research specifically focused on AI usability and user sentiments
- Group discussions with leaders in the technology and academic communities:
 - University of Baltimore faculty, staff, and students
 - Leaders of the technology business community
 - Community organizers
 - Baltimore City officials
- A closed survey for group-discussion participants to report their AI usage habits, hopes, and concerns
- A public survey asking participants to report their AI usage habits, hopes, and concerns
- One-on-one interviews with AI users and people familiar with AI tools

Exploration Methods

Our approach was grounded in applied ethnography and qualitative research methods, focusing on theme identification through semi-structured conversations. It was important for us to understand the “why” and the “how” around user sentiments, rather than exclusively looking at quantitative data left open to interpretation.

Guiding interview topics included:

- Individual AI usage
- Understanding of AI tools and platforms
- Opinions on perceived societal impact of AI tools
- Baltimore-specific opportunities

Targeting Respondents

The team conducted a survey to collect data from a wide range of audiences and gauge initial sentiment, interest, and experience. The research team conducted six virtual in-depth interviews with respondents to gather additional details and insights across a range of perspectives on AI, industries, and Baltimore neighborhoods.

By the numbers:

Our team fielded responses from:

- 6 group discussions of 10–12 participants
- 9 individual interviews
- 51 closed- and open-survey participants

Who responded:

- Leaders of the Baltimore tech community
- Startup and small business owners
- Academic researchers and educators from several Maryland universities
 - Specific fields included AI, information technology, business, legal, and integrated arts
- Baltimore City officials
- Community organizers and nonprofit leaders
- Everyday Baltimoreans whose jobs are currently impacted by AI

Overarching Findings

Common Themes

AI as a “calculator”

Multiple respondents compared AI to a calculator — a tool to expedite tedious tasks

AI training is lacking

Respondents noted their employers have not offered robust AI training or guidelines

AI impacts student growth

There are concerns around how heavy usage could negatively impact students’ cognitive function

AI as a second brain

AI users noted they would not trust AI to complete tasks they themselves could not do

AI users tend to overgeneralize

Respondents often conflated “AI” with Large Language Models (LLMs) like ChatGPT or Claude, misinterpreting other capabilities

AI’s impact on environment

Many respondents noted concerns around environmental impact and a desire for some regulation

Artificial Intelligence ...

- Fosters ambition
- Boosts productivity
- Rewires digital behaviors and habits
- Disrupts our social and professional constructs
- Raises environmental concerns
- Shapes technology education and future generations

Primary Takeaway

AI is a gateway to an uncharted future.

Meet Baltimore's AI Users

Why User Personas?

A user persona is a loose narrative that represents a composite of multiple people who share common traits and stories. Personas are used to better conceptualize real people with unique needs, motivations, and backgrounds **to better visualize and empathize with users**, rather than in abstract categories such as “citizens” or “users.”

These tools are intended to help us think in new ways about the types of people who use AI. Defining clear pictures of the people who use (or don't use) AI tools will help us uncover new opportunities for AI as they relate to Baltimore City.

These profiles are not exhaustive or mutually exclusive; they represent the types of individuals across Baltimore who may adopt AI tools when solving day-to-day problems.

How to Read the Personas?

Each persona represents a pattern of needs, concerns, motivations, and opportunities.

The question is not simply, "Who is this person?"

The question is, "What does this persona help Baltimore understand, do, target, or rethink?"

Meet Baltimore's AI users

Heavy AI user & believer

Moderate AI user, but cautious

Non-AI user & resistant



The
**Civic
Champion**



The
**Student
Superuser**



The
**Adaptive
Achiever**



The
**Prudent
Professor**



The
**Hometown
Hero**



The
**Labor
Guardian**



Active AI User

The Civic Champion

A current AI user leveraging technology to make Baltimore more responsive, equitable, and data-informed.

Age

38

Likely Occupations

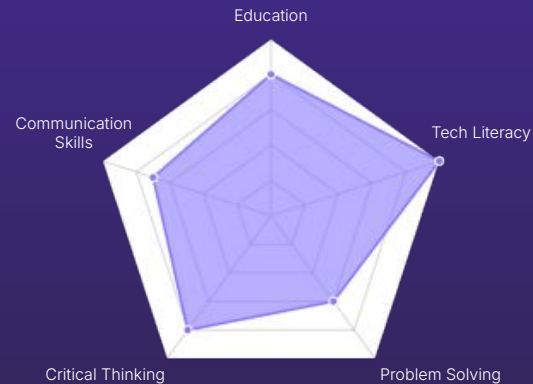
- Data Analyst and Engineer for the City of Baltimore
- City planner for the Department of Planning
- Emergency analyst for the 911 Center

Likely Locations

City Hall offices, police precinct data rooms, community association meetings, and local coffee shops between briefings

"We don't need more data — we need better decisions. AI helps us get there faster, but only if we stay accountable."

"We won't see systemic change until we, the people, grab the opportunity to make AI work for us."



Understanding of AI



Attitude towards AI



Community Influence



Political Influence





Active AI User

The Civic Champion

A current AI user leveraging technology to make Baltimore more responsive, equitable, and data-informed.

Background

Growing up in West Baltimore, the Civic Champion witnessed firsthand the uneven distribution of city resources. Delayed trash pickup was one thing — missing street signs and graffiti on his block was another. After earning an IT degree from a state university, they returned to Baltimore with a clear mission: to help the government take more action using the right data.

Now working as a city official, they advocate for ways to make data actually work for Baltimoreans. They regularly collaborate with council members, community leaders, and first responders to translate data into policy. They're deeply embedded in the operational heartbeat of the city, whether analyzing the city's service requests or helping city employees allocate their resources more effectively.

They may frequently attend neighborhood association and city council meetings to give a voice to the city's data operations. Residents know they're not just some faceless "tech guy" for the city, but someone deeply invested in bridging the gap between bureaucracy and community.

The Civic Champion is highly aware of Baltimore's systemic inequities, particularly the "resource gap" that is often mistaken for a skills gap in underserved communities like the one he grew up in. He sees his role not just as a technologist, but as a civic steward — ensuring innovation reaches and benefits those who have been left out too often before.



Active AI User

The Civic Champion

A current AI user leveraging technology to make Baltimore more responsive, equitable, and data-informed.

Experience with AI

The Civic Champion is a pragmatic AI user who's found ways to integrate it directly into their personal daily workflows and across city operations. They might use it to aggregate and analyze large datasets — especially 311 reports, infrastructure complaints, and traffic camera data — to find trends and surface issues that would often take weeks (or even months) to identify and correct. They're particularly interested in using AI to find community-level insights that can drive neighborhood-led action, like identifying service gaps or uncovering quality-of-life issues like unpaved streets or illegal graffiti.

Their response is measured when using AI as a rapid synthesis tool. They're aware AI can produce convincing but flawed outputs and emphasize the need for constant validation, especially when decisions impact public policy.

The Civic Champion also plays an informal educator role within city government, helping colleagues understand that AI is an “amplifier” — it strengthens good judgment but can just as easily magnify poor decision-making if used uncritically. This belief fuels his advocacy for broader AI literacy across departments and communities.

Despite their optimism, the Civic Champion maintains a firm stance on human oversight. They view AI as an “over-eager assistant,” not a decision-maker, and believe that accountability must always remain with people — not systems.



Active AI User

The Student Superuser

An AI early adopter preparing to enter his early career stages.

Age

22

Likely Occupations

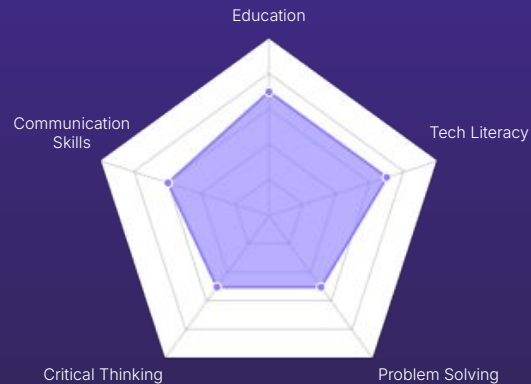
- Senior finance major at a Baltimore university
- Local Baltimore high schooler
- Part-time student in a continuing education program

Likely Locations

In the university library, at a table in their local café, in their dorm lounge or bedroom, or at the gym during a workout.

"I'm getting my assignments done in half the time it usually takes — why wouldn't I use it?"

"Trust me, it's only going to get better as we keep using it."



Understanding of AI



Attitude towards AI



Community Influence



Political Influence





Active AI User

The Student Superuser

An AI early adopter preparing to enter his early career stages.

Background

The Student Superuser may have had a good head for numbers since he was a kid. Growing up in South Baltimore, they started their own small business, like a neighborhood grocery delivery service, in the middle of high school.

They have an entrepreneurial spirit and declared a finance or other business major in hopes it would offer a secure line of post-graduate work. They spend most of their school time either preparing for group projects and presentations, studying in the business school's facilities, or finding some quiet time in the library.

The Student Superuser might be finishing up a major academic milestone, like senior year or a semester capstone project, or preparing to enter the world of business. They're often avid contributors or at least consumers of the r/stocks subreddit, and may be casually starting some trading. They may be ready to consider day trading as a fallback if their career search stalls. They could also be considering a postgraduate MBA program to bolster their career opportunities.



Active AI User

The Student Superuser

An AI early adopter preparing to enter his early career stages.

Experience with AI

ChatGPT burst onto the scene and became a household name around the time that the Student Superuser was finishing high school. They decided to test it out early, always enjoying new technologies and ways to make better use of their time. They experiment with AI drafting outlines for their college essays at first, increasing their ability to fill out more college applications than they would have expected.

As they plod through their rigorous math and financial philosophy courses of freshman year — and as AI outputs improved — the Student Superuser starts to build tasks and AI agents to analyze historical data to project market trends. They're able to identify outcomes more quickly and efficiently in take-home assignments. They're also using AI to speed up their study techniques, having it create flashcards and practice tests.

As agentic AI becomes more integrated into daily life, they've doubled down on its time-saving benefits. They're creating routine tasks for it to find viable job openings and submit their resume and cover letters. As an amateur trader, the Student Superuser might be working on an agentic bot to identify market opportunities by trends that occur before the stock starts to surge. It's a slow effort, but a number of their friends and classmates are starting to pool data to make the tool even better.



Active AI User

The Adaptive Achiever

A high-performing, non-traditional learner who uses AI as a cognitive support system — but is determined not to lose their independence in the process.

Age

42

Likely Occupations

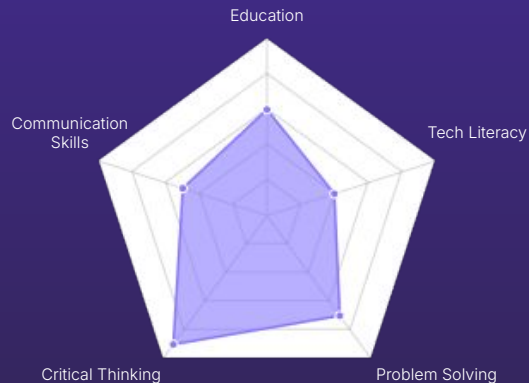
- Small business owner
- Community program coordinator
- Part-time graduate student

Likely Locations

Working late at their laptop, juggling coursework and responsibilities, in campus common areas, at community meetings, or switching between tasks throughout the day

"Opting out of using these tools feels like a privilege in itself. With everything I have going on, I can't afford not to use it."

"It helps me process things the way my brain needs, but I still have to make sure the ideas are mine."



Understanding of AI



Attitude towards AI



Community Influence



Political Influence





Active AI User

The Adaptive Achiever

A high-performing, non-traditional learner who uses AI as a cognitive support system — but is determined not to lose their independence in the process.

Background

The Adaptive Achiever took a non-linear path back into higher education, returning as an adult learner while managing work and 'round-the-clock involvement with a community organization. Their days are tightly scheduled, often requiring context shifts between roles — student, professional, community organizer — without much room for error.

The Adaptive Achiever may have different learning disabilities or preferences that impact how they see things differently from many of their peers. She takes more time to filter through dense readings, abstract instructions, and high volumes of written material. These were hard limits in a standardized school system at first, but with time, practice, and mental modeling techniques, they've learned to overcome those difficulties. That means they do a lot of rereading, rewriting, and mental processing to get a clear picture in their mind. It's how they stay competitive, but it's also exhausting.

Despite this, the Adaptive Achiever consistently performs at a high level. They are thoughtful, articulate, and highly intentional in how they communicate — likely in part because of her rigorous efforts. They take pride in producing work that reflects their voice and perspective, especially in environments where they feel like they have to prove that they belong. That feeling of immediate adversity only pushes their desire to articulate their work as their own.



Active AI User

The Adaptive Achiever

A high-performing, non-traditional learner who uses AI as a cognitive support system — but is determined not to lose their independence in the process.

Experience with AI

For the Adaptive Achiever, AI goes beyond its use as a productivity tool, making learning and processing itself a more accessible function for them. It helps them summarize dense and overwhelming textual information so they can engage with it quickly and more efficiently. They're able to get up to speed on complex expense reports, business documents, and meeting minutes without having to reset focus as frequently.

They also use it to refine tone and clarity in their writing, especially in both their school and work settings, where precision matters. It serves as a checkpoint — helping them confirm that what she's trying to say is actually coming through.

At the same time, the Adaptive Achiever's relationship with AI is carefully managed. They are wary of becoming dependent on it, particularly in ways that might erode critical thinking or voice. If something feels too polished or disconnected from her intent, they rewrite it. They may wait until they're done reviewing their personal notes before consulting the AI's recommendations.

The Adaptive Achiever sees AI as a powerful tool — but only when it's used to support critical thought, not replace it. Maintaining that boundary is essential to how they define both their work and sense of capability.



Hesitant AI User

The Prudent Professor

An educator who's concerned about the long-term implications of AI reliance.

Age

52

Likely Occupations

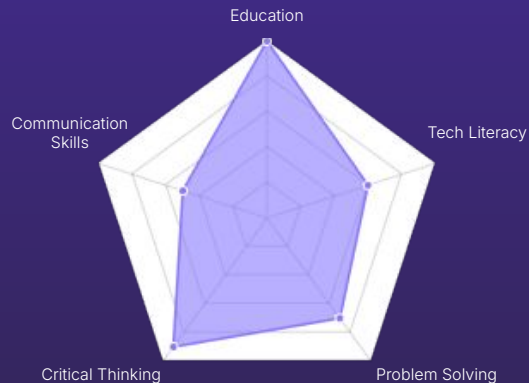
- Professor of Environmental Science at a Baltimore university
- Research scientist at an urban-integrated field lab
- Lab technician at the Maryland Department of Health Environmental Sciences

Likely Locations

In the field in a mobile lab performing data collection, in a lab analyzing data, in their office on campus

"The upsides are clear, but the long-term impact is still so murky. We need more time and research to study how we respond to it."

"I'll sleep a lot better at night if we can find ways to offset the environmental impact of it all."



Understanding of AI



Attitude towards AI



Community Influence



Political Influence





Hesitant AI User

The Prudent Professor

An educator who's concerned about the long-term implications of AI reliance.

Background

The Prudent Professor often grows up as the child of academics, scholars, or environmental activists. Their middle school science projects focused on local ecology efforts, like measuring waste and contaminants in the Chesapeake Bay. You see shadows of this in their later Ph.D. or professional research, like improving the city's stormwater management to benefit marine ecosystems in and around the Inner Harbor.

The Prudent Professor saw a worrying trend as Baltimore's notoriously hot and humid summers were growing hotter and more humid. As a result, their studies gravitated toward climate change. They noticed an opportunity for long-term studies to measure the phenomenon, and they pivoted once again more toward climate science.

The Prudent Professor may spend a lot of time in outdoor labs measuring water samples, but also looking at weather patterns and how they trend year-over-year. Their field experience equates to engaging classroom environments, and their students generally value their field time — but the mountain of data they collect is vast, and deciphering it all is painstaking work.



Hesitant AI User

The Prudent Professor

An educator who's concerned about the long-term implications of AI reliance.

Experience with AI

The Prudent Professor is a naturally curious person who has spent a lot of spare time reading and investigating the positive and negative effects of AI usage. While the benefits are undeniable, there are still concerns about the long-term impacts that AI tools have on the way we work and solve problems, not to mention the environmental impact.

One way the Prudent Professor sees a major benefit in using AI is to parse their massive data sets. However, whenever they do get a readout, they spend a good deal of time verifying that the outputs are hallucination-free. The readouts are mostly clean, but when they aren't, the Prudent Professor feels like they have to start from scratch. These negative interactions lead them to wonder whether AI is worth the energy usage.

The Prudent Professor sometimes belongs to an academic department that heavily encourages their instructors to use AI, but they have not received strict guidelines, training, or any detailed acceptable use documentation. The department also recommended that they embrace their pupils' AI use. The Prudent Professor feels like this is a lot to learn in such a short period of time. They often worry whether students are actually retaining anything, even though the quality of their work remains somewhat unchanged.



Hesitant AI User

The Hometown Hero

A hard-working Baltimore native who's struggling to see the value of AI in their day-to-day.

Age

49

Likely Occupations

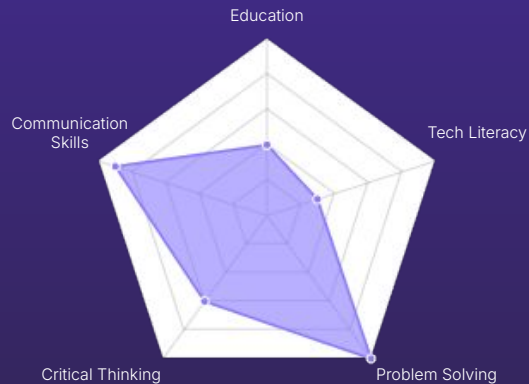
- A BGE lineman with 20 years of experience
- A neighborhood trades business owner
- A short-haul FTL freight driver

Likely Locations

In their service truck, at job sites, at home watching local news, or at neighborhood gatherings

"AI feels less like some tool, and more like something that's happening to me, and there's nothing I can do about it."

"Everybody's talking about it, but I don't see anyone using it in a way that's helping me or my friends and family."



Understanding of AI



Attitude towards AI



Community Influence



Political Influence





Hesitant AI User

The Hometown Hero

A hard-working Baltimore native who's struggling to see the value of AI in their day-to-day.

Background

The Hometown Hero's world and work are physical, immediate, and essential — problems are solved with tools, experience, and teamwork. No need for anything fancy — just trust the process.

Within their neighborhood community, they're reliable and respected. They're the first people neighbors call when an appliance breaks or they have a DIY problem at home to fix.

The Hometown Hero often didn't grow up with a computer at home, but their child frequently uses a laptop for schoolwork. They use a smartphone for work, but any extracurricular activity on it is spent mostly just browsing websites and some occasional social media.

They've grown annoyed by what they see on the news and on their news feeds — like most of the world feels overly complicated now, like no one can stand to be patient anymore. The rapid pace of change creates a deeper level of quiet frustration. It's not that they're against new tools — they're just all coming out so fast that they don't have time to learn them all.



Hesitant AI User

The Hometown Hero

A hard-working Baltimore native who's struggling to see the value of AI in their day-to-day.

Experience with AI

The Hometown Hero says they don't use AI tools — or at least they're not aware they do. They may have tried using a few chatbots on some websites, but they had a hard time seeing how it was productive. All the tools their children use for schoolwork feel foreign and vague, like they don't know where to start or they're doing something wrong. More than anything, they don't trust what is happening in the code in the background.

There are moments where AI could genuinely help them — deciphering technical documents or simplifying their day-to-day logistics — but those connections haven't been made for the Hometown Hero in a clear or accessible way. They often don't have any guidance from their company on how they are supposed to use AI, so they're just putting it off for as long as they possibly can.

Most of their exposure to AI is secondhand, through 30-second media clips and the occasional headline about jobs being replaced or systems going wrong. It all feels fuzzy and impractical, like the Internet did back in the '90s. Sometimes AI is portrayed as revolutionary; other times it's a danger. Who's going to have their back if the city starts putting up AI-powered cameras everywhere and their neighborhood becomes a surveillance state?

The Hometown Hero doesn't trust what the headlines say — they may be skeptical of most news sources — but there's still a loud voice in the back of his mind that won't quiet down that a change is coming. Where does it leave people like them moving forward?



AI Resister

The Labor Guardian

A workforce advocate who sees AI as a growing threat to job security, professional value, and human-centered work.

Age

39

Likely Occupations

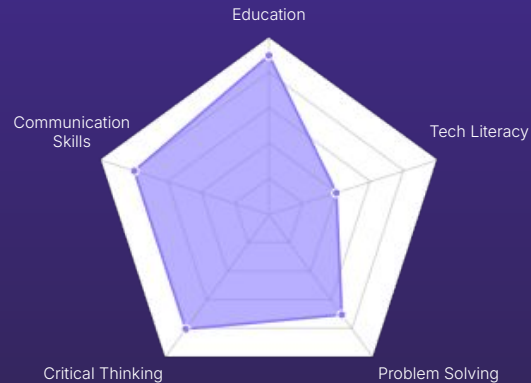
- Teacher union representative
- Public school educator
- Education administrator or school board member

Likely Locations

None or very few; actively resists AI usage

"I've read this story before. Somehow, new technology always ends up exploiting the working class."

"Every time they call it 'efficiency,' somebody's job — or judgment — gets pushed out of the picture."



Understanding of AI



Attitude towards AI



Community Influence



Political Influence





AI Resister

The Labor Guardian

A workforce advocate who sees AI as a growing threat to job security, professional value, and human-centered work.

Background

The Labor Guardian spent years working inside Baltimore's public education system at some point, possibly transitioning into a broader workforce advocacy role. Their work centers on supporting educators and public sector employees as they navigate policy and budget shifts, while their expectations are ever-evolving and increasing.

Through that experience, the Labor Guardian developed a somewhat pessimistic view of how higher-ups make decisions that impact people at the front lines of education. They see new technologies introduced with promises of support and efficiency. Too often, it's resulted in added pressure, reduced budget, and misaligned procedures.

The Labor Guardian's perspective is rooted in relationships. They firmly believe that human connection and care are what drive success in this sector. Whether in a classroom or a municipal workplace, they believe the quality of human interaction — mentorship, judgment, lived experience — is what drives real outcomes.

They are also deeply aware of Baltimore's technological context. Many of the communities they work with are already navigating instability. The Labor Guardian views rapid technological change as a means to further marginalize working- and middle-class families. They increasingly see themselves as protectors, advocating for those who fulfill a duty to society and feel like the favor isn't always returned.



AI Resister

The Labor Guardian

A workforce advocate who sees AI as a growing threat to job security, professional value, and human-centered work.

Experience with AI

The Labor Guardian has spent enough time around AI to understand its capabilities, and they don't like what they've seen so far. They've experimented with it in limited ways — mostly by putting it through rigorous logical tests to gauge individual models' tendency for sycophancy and hallucinations.

What concerns them most is how it's implemented. They've seen examples of AI-generated reports, communications, and evaluations that lack context and, at times, accuracy. In the Labor Guardian's view, these tools have only led to professional detachment and decreased quality.

In workplace settings, they're particularly concerned about over-reliance. In school environments, they're worried about a lack of development during a child's most important milestones. They believe that when people begin outsourcing their core skills, we risk weakening the very skills that make us valuable.

They see AI as part of a larger societal shift toward cost-cutting over quality and human autonomy. They're an active advocate against AI in schools for both students and faculty, and for protections to ensure educators are central to developing curricula and lesson planning.

When will the Labor Guardian feel comfortable using AI? As soon as they feel certain that the people who count on their work won't be replaced by AI. And even then, that's a stretch.

What the Personas Reveal: From Insights to Action

What Did We Learn Across the Personas

Civic Champion, Prudent Professor, Hometown Hero, Labor Guardian, and active AI users across the research. These personas show that AI use is already shaping civic work, education, productivity, and everyday problem-solving — but unevenly and with different levels of confidence and concern.

What the Data Tells Us

- AI understanding varies widely — from confident daily users to residents who are uncertain what AI is or where it appears in daily life.
- Many users still associate AI primarily with tools like ChatGPT or Claude, which can limit understanding of AI's broader role in work, education, public services, and decision-making.
- Some users are already treating AI as a "second brain" for writing, planning, organizing, brainstorming, and problem-solving.
- Practical value is a major driver of adoption: people are more likely to use AI when it helps them save time, increase capacity, or pursue goals they already care about.
- At the same time, concerns remain around trust, overuse, accuracy, student learning, human judgment, environmental impact, and who benefits from AI adoption.

What Does This Mean for Baltimore?

***Civic Champion** highlights the potential for AI to support more responsive public service when paired with human validation. **Prudent Professor** surfaces concerns about student growth, cognitive development, and uneven institutional guidance. **Labor Guardian** and **Hometown Hero** point to the need for workforce support, trust-building, and practical pathways into AI use*

What the Data Tells Us

- AI efforts are emerging across workplaces, classrooms, civic systems, community spaces, and public services, but many remain disconnected.
- Residents and professionals are often experimenting with AI before institutions have provided clear training, policies, or acceptable-use guidance.
- The gap between confident AI users and hesitant or unsupported users may widen without practical education and trusted learning pathways.
- AI adoption is not only a technology issue. It affects work, learning, public trust, quality of life, environmental responsibility, and civic decision-making.
- Baltimore needs a measured approach that helps people understand AI, use it well, question it appropriately, and apply it where it can create real value.

What Can Stakeholders Do With This Information?

***Civic Champion** shows how AI can be used to analyze public service patterns and identify community needs, but also reinforces that AI should support — not replace — human accountability. **Prudent Professor** shows the need for institutional guidance in education. **Labor Guardian** and **Hometown Hero** help stakeholders think about work, mobility, trust, and practical adoption.*

How Does the Data Serve as a Compass?

- **Educators** can use the personas to design AI literacy programs that support learning, critical thinking, and appropriate use.
- **Employers and workforce organizations** can use the personas to identify where workers need training, guidance, and clearer expectations.
- **Community organizations** can use the personas to create trusted learning spaces for residents who are curious, skeptical, overwhelmed, or unsure where to begin.
- **Civic leaders and public agencies** can use the personas to ask better questions about when AI should support decisions, where human oversight is required, and how services could become more responsive.
- **CAILI and partners** can use this work as a compass for cross-sector coordination, future research, public learning, and responsible adoption.

What Needs More Validation?

***All personas** require validation. The Summit Town Halls are designed to stress-test these profiles, identify what is accurate, surface what is missing, and help Baltimore evolve the personas into a stronger framework for understanding the city's AI ecosystem.*

Does the Data Reflect the Landscape?

- Do these personas accurately reflect how Baltimore stakeholders understand, use, question, or avoid AI?
- Which persona descriptions feel familiar to educators, employers, community leaders, civic agencies, and residents — and which feel incomplete?
- Are the motivations, concerns, barriers, and opportunities connected to each persona accurate across different neighborhoods, institutions, and age groups?
- How are these personas changing as AI tools become more common in school, work, public services, and daily life?
- What would make these personas more useful for planning programs, policies, outreach, training, and community engagement?

What Gaps Still Remain?

- Which Baltimore residents, neighborhoods, and community contexts are not yet fully represented in the persona research?
- Which groups are affected by AI systems even if they are not actively choosing to use AI tools?
- How do AI experiences differ for older adults, youth, families, small business owners, public-sector workers, educators, workers in transition, and residents with limited digital access?
- What questions remain about AI's impact on quality of life, trust, learning, employment, public services, and environmental responsibility?
- What additional research, listening, and community engagement are needed to build a fuller picture of Baltimore's AI future?

This is Baltimore's Starting Point

The personas are not final profiles. They are a starting compass for understanding, validating, and shaping Baltimore's AI future.



The
**Student
Superuser**



The
**Civic
Champion**



The
**Prudent
Professor**



The
**Hometown
Hero**



The
**Labor
Guardian**



The
**Adaptive
Achiever**

What Now?

- This report provides a first framework for understanding Baltimore's AI users, non-users, skeptics, builders, educators, workers, and civic actors.
- The next step is to test these personas with the people and institutions they are meant to inform.
- The Summit creates an opportunity to validate what is accurate, challenge what is incomplete, and identify what Baltimore still needs to learn.
- Over time, these personas can help guide AI education, workforce planning, civic innovation, community engagement, and measured adoption.
- The value of the personas is not only what they describe — it is what they help Baltimore do next.

Thank you!

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